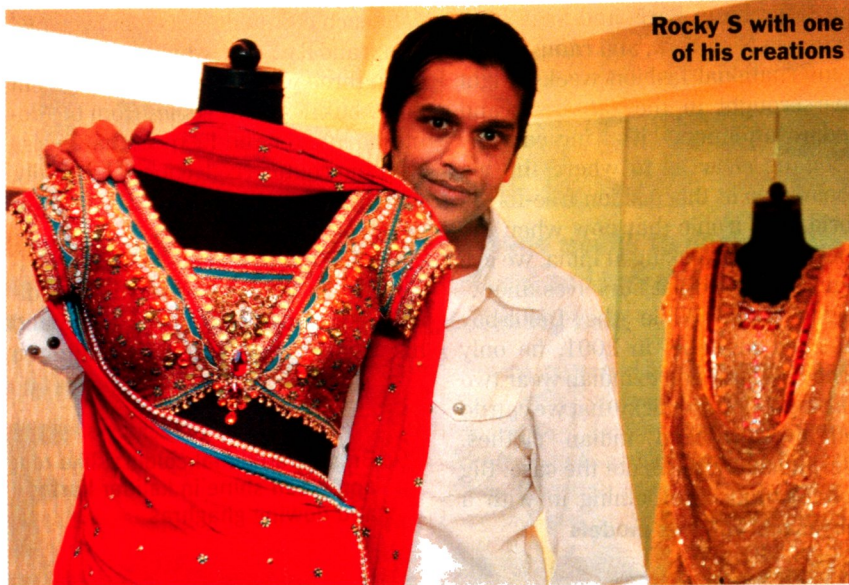




Rocky S with one of his creations



ROCKY S

The look is a mix of contemporary and traditional. Colours vary from traditional reds, oranges to pastels.

festive line that promises to tinge her spring-summer collection at Lakme Fashion Week (LFW) too.

Refreshingly enough, each of these designers are bringing their own flavour to the bursting bridal bouquet. "Whether western clothes or Indian wear, I use zari and gota in the same placement," says Bahl. So, while Gupta brings his esoteric, global look to his saris, Rocky transfers his stylish chic to a corset and mermaid skirt. "I have used non-typical colour combinations like burgundy and turquoise to lend a different edge to my Indian ensembles," says Tawadey.

into the luxe rich lehenga market, while having claimed in the past that nearly 90 per cent of their business came from international sales. "We were getting a lot of trousseau orders and so we started out doing customised bridal wear. And since the response was good we launched our first bridal collection Peacock Bride that bears our signature style," says Falguni. So, a Peacock bridal ensemble teams teal blue, turquoise, burnt orange and peach into stylised ghaghra and unconventionally-cut blouses with zardozi and feathers, for that touch of whimsy. "We believe in marrying the conventional with the contemporary and designing lehengas that can be worn with Manolo Blahnik or Jimmy Choo pumps," she says.

Newcomers like Tawadey are fast catching on to market mechanics and discovering the viable delights of desi demands. "Commercially, western clothes aren't proving to be very feasible. One can't compete with the price lines of mass-produced brands like Mango. Saris and salwar kameez not only have a wider appeal, but buyers are willing to shell out more money for them," says Tawadey. She recently launched her first-ever Indian



SARANG SENA



GAURAV GUPTA

The vintage mood is heightened with deeper reds, pinks, parrot green with antique gold and silver.

And, even as a new fashion season is set to see international buyers wining and dining, it's the domestic buyers who are having the last laugh. Says Tina Tahiliani of Ensemble, "It is the designers who have to decide the size and focus of their business. If you want to do substantial business in India, you cannot restrict yourself to just western wear. Designers like Varun Bahl, Gaurav Gupta and Monisha Jaising have seen the size of their markets go up dramatically the moment they entered the domestic arena."

So while designer store racks are bursting with saris from Gupta and ghaghra from Bahl, you are unlikely to see them on the Wills Lifestyle India Fashion Week ramp, anytime soon. For Bahl, it is a pure business decision. "In India, I already have a presence in the stores I want to be in. Fashion week collections are for the international clientele," he asserts. Mukherjee, on the other hand, is taking his local liaison to LFW with an evident Indian touch in his spring-summer collection, dedicated to his desi devotees.

From a global outlook to narrowing down to a local viewpoint, looks like India's trendsetters have now set the couture cash cow grazing in parochial pastures. From peddling pret at Prêt À Porter Paris to selling swish saris in South Block and trans-India trousseau trunk shows, desi designers are going local and lucrative.